

The Net Threat

Everyone gets online from their offices today, but doing so carelessly could cost your business some serious money

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In a recent survey of a small number of people, our very own Agent 001 uncovered an appalling truth: many people access the Net at work for just the things they do at home! Read more about the fun stuff people do with any available bandwidth in the *Digital Leisure* section of this issue. What's dangerous is that they could be doing this in your office. Apart from the legal ramifications, your security, too, might be unwittingly compromised by an employee who doesn't understand the consequences of his actions. The onus is therefore on the company to inform employees about how the Net should be used at work—and possibly even monitor their actions.

Most of your employees are getting online, checking e-mail, chatting, surfing, Googling, and playing online games—unless you've specifically blocked access. With all this Internet activity going on, you have to think about the threats posed by hackers, crackers, phishers, and the other "ers" out there. Every second day there's a new exploit, threat, worm and/or virus detected, which puts your data at risk. Now, the very people you employ could unwittingly turn out to be threats to your company—if they're oblivious to the dangers that Internet access brings with it.

Human Engineering

This is a term used to refer to the ploys used by attackers to fool people out of money or data. With Internet banking and a host of other online services being offered by banks, phishing is on

the rise. From eBay clones to banking site rip-offs, there are thousands of sites that claim to be what they're not. Advancements in Web coding means that a phisher can even hide the address bar of his site, thus making a user believe they're really at a bank site.

Most phishing attacks come via e-mail, where a user is asked to click on a disguised link, and then update some information. Now if one of these users happens to be an accountant or someone with access to your company bank account, you could be in serious trouble. It is of utmost importance that you educate your employees about the phishing threat.

One fix is to make all your employees see their mails in text format, in which case the problem of disguised links is eliminated. If Outlook is the e-mail client you use, go to **Tools > Options**, and under the e-mail header, click on the "E-mail Options" button. Here, check "Read all standard mail in plain text", and then check the "Read all digitally signed mail in plain text" box. Even if text in an e-mail asks to copy and paste a link into a browser, your employees are probably smart enough to make out, from the text of the link, where they'll be going!

The Real Threats

With Internet penetration increasing by the hour, fewer people are falling prey to human engineering. More and more hackers and crackers are therefore focusing their attention on finding ways and means to infect your computers with bugs that will allow them to gain access to your computers and their data.

For a company, data is money; whether it's

